

A Dual Enrollment Postsecondary Education Program for Students with Intellectual Disabilities: Winthrop Transition to College

Debra Leach, Lynn Helms, Michelle Foster, Antigo Martin-Delaney, and Caroline Everington

The Winthrop University Transition to College (WTC) program, a dual enrollment program for high school students with intellectual disabilities, has recently begun its fifth year. Winthrop is a public university in Rock Hill, SC, with approximately 6,000 students from diverse backgrounds. The WTC program typically serves eight to ten high school students from two local school districts. The WTC program is an extension of the special education services offered in each district as a placement for community based instruction (CBI) with three primary requirements: participating students a) are 18-21 years old, b) have an intellectual disability, and c) have completed four years of the district's occupational diploma program. Using person-centered planning, students choose one or two regular Winthrop courses each semester, an employment setting, and recreational activities on campus. All placements are based on the students' strengths and interests and involve full participation with traditional Winthrop students.

HOW IT BEGAN: PILOTING THE WTC PROGRAM

WTC planning began in spring 2008, when members of the local Transition Advisory Council (TAC) approached Winthrop University to discuss the possibility of forming a partnership to develop and implement an alternative educational experience for students with intellectual disabilities ages 18-21 who were unlikely to qualify for a regular high school diploma. The TAC sought opportunities beyond those typically available at high schools to expand community-based learning options and prepare students for employment and independence. Winthrop faculty expressed a keen interest in developing a partnership and

over the next few months, an advisory board consisting of the College of Education associate dean, two Winthrop professors, two high school teachers, and the transition coordinators from the two participating school districts came together and created the WTC program.

During this planning period, the advisory board visited three South Carolina universities with existing postsecondary programs for students with ID. These programs were all tuition-based and available only to students who had already exited high school. To capitalize on the existing partnership between Winthrop and the local school districts, the advisory board decided to commit to using the dual enrollment model.

The pilot program was launched in fall 2008. The entering cohort consisted of eight students from high schools in Rock Hill and Fort Mill, South Carolina. Navigation of the campus and independence were the primary focus of the first semester. Students in this pilot cohort attended Winthrop three days a week during the first semester and quickly became acclimated by using a variety of campus resources such as the library, cafeteria, and recreation center. Some group instruction was provided to teach skills for navigating the campus and using campus resources.

Special education majors who were enrolled in a course on ID helped identify specific campus environments in which most traditional Winthrop students engage on a regular basis (e.g., food court, library, recreation center, computer lab, student lounge, copy center). The special education majors then used ecological assessment procedures to identify the skills needed to fully participate in each environment. By the second semester, a person-centered planning process was

used to help the students to select their college classes. Faculty members involved in the project had previous experience with full inclusion in other settings, and knew that buy-in from other Winthrop faculty was essential for success. Conversations were initiated with faculty members who would be teaching the courses that WTC students selected. Initially, some faculty members had apprehension about including a WTC student in their classes. To address this, the WTC program coordinator attended the first class or two and quickly faded out once the faculty members were comfortable.

After the pilot year, the cohort expanded to ten students. Schedules were coordinated so that students were able to take multiple courses each semester while also participating in job training and recreational activities on campus. Job coaches and peer mentors assisted the WTC students in all aspect of campus involvement. Participants in the program have not only benefited academically, but also have become independent and self-determined in achieving their goals. Campus job training experiences have led to permanent employment for three participants. Friendships and partnerships have evolved across campus. Many students and faculty have expressed a new appreciation of the diverse abilities and contributions of individuals with ID.

CRITICAL FEATURES OF THE WTC PROGRAM

Peer mentors

A WTC peer mentor is an enrolled Winthrop student who consistently provides academic/classroom, social, and/or employment-related support to a WTC student. Under the guidance of the WTC program coordinator and school district staff, peer mentors share their knowledge, model interpersonal skills, and promote self-advocacy, self-determination, and independence. They have proven to be reliable and enthusiastic partners in the education of the WTC students.

Access to Courses

Students in the WTC program are not restricted to classes within the College of Education, nor have special courses been developed exclusively for them. Person-centered planning sessions are used to determine typical college courses, social/recreational experiences, and work experiences for each WTC student. While parents, mentors, district teachers, and Winthrop faculty contribute ideas and suggestions, each WTC student determines his/her final schedule. WTC peer mentors also often suggest classes and social experiences for WTC students. In fact, it is not unusual for a WTC student to request a particular course because he/she overheard a traditional Winthrop student discussing topics or activities learned in the class.

Great care is taken at the beginning of each semester to ensure that WTC students feel comfortable with their chosen classes. Whenever possible, WTC students meet with their instructors prior to the first day of class. Often, the WTC student and peer mentor will do a practice run of the student's schedule the first week of a new semester.

Work experiences

WTC students choose from a variety of paid and unpaid work experiences across campus. Work sites are chosen by the WTC students based on their personal interests and goals and include the MacFeat Child Development Center, DiGorgio Campus Center, the Bookworm (campus bookstore), the Men's Basketball Team, West Center (campus recreational complex), and the campus post office. Parents and school district personnel collaborate with Winthrop staff to make placements and align necessary supports. Employers are highly satisfied with the work done by WTC students.

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BENEFITS OF THE DUAL ENROLLMENT APPROACH

There are many benefits of a dual enrollment approach to postsecondary opportunities for students with intellectual disabilities.

Minimal cost to families

First, the WTC program does not cost families a lot of money or require families to apply for financial aid. As part of students' transition services, a dual enrollment approach allows families to take advantage of school district services until their child is 21 but also experience the postsecondary environment.

Two sets of support personnel

Second, because the students are receiving school district services, there are many professional and support staff available to help ensure their success, including a transition coordinator, the classroom teacher from the high school, and the paraprofessionals who serve as job coaches. These collaborators make the work of the WTC coordinator much easier. However, although high school personnel accompany students to campus, they are only there to support coursework requirements outside of instructional or job settings. Natural supports are used whenever possible (Soresi, Nota, & Wehmeyer, 2011). Winthrop students without disabilities provide peer supports in class or work settings.

OBSTACLES TO THE DUAL ENROLLMENT APPROACH

Transportation

Coordination of class schedules and transportation to and from campus has been difficult when campus schedules and the traditional high school day differ—this is especially challenging for Rock Hill, as this community has no public transportation. Transportation has to be provided by the school district, and each student has a different schedule of activities on campus. A close working partnership with school district personnel and families has been critical to our success

in coordinating schedules. Lead teachers from the high schools developed school-level procedures regarding student scheduling, staffing, and transportation and occasionally families provide rides to the college.

Funding

Securing ongoing funding has proven challenging, and the program's growth is limited by the funding available. The school districts have to consider the dual enrollment program a transition service that is worth supporting financially. The initial years were completely funded by grants from the College Transition Connection (CTC), at no cost to the participant or school district. However, when the grant funds have ended, the school districts will be required to cover the program costs. The WTC advisory board continues to seek grants and donations in an effort to ease the financial burden on the districts.

SUMMARY

After four years, it is clear that the WTC program is beneficial for the participants, for traditional Winthrop students, and for Winthrop faculty and staff. WTC participants enjoy a rich college experience while developing academic, social, communication, employability, and independent living skills. The other students and the faculty and staff are not only learning to accept and include individuals with ID, but are learning the value that these individuals add to the campus community. This will likely impact their understanding of and appreciation for individuals with ID when they are in settings outside of the university.

For more information about the Winthrop Transition to College program, visit (www2.winthrop.edu/transitioncollege/).

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REFERENCE

Soresi, S., Nota, L., & Wehmeyer, M. L. (2011). Community involvement in promoting inclusion, participation and self-determination. *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, 15(1), 15–28.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Debra Leach is Assistant Professor of Special Education at Winthrop University and the director of the WTC program.

Lynn Helms is a special education teacher in Rock Hill, SC and a WTC advisory board member.

Michelle Foster is a certified special education teacher who is the WTC program coordinator and advisory board member.

Antigo Martin-Delaney is Associate Professor of Psychology at Winthrop University and a WTC advisory board member.

Caroline Everington is Associate Dean of the College of Education at Winthrop University and a WTC advisory board member.

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